



FROST DATES & SEASON

Last frost: March 22 – April 15
First frost: October 20 – November 10
Season: 190–225 days

THIS MONTH — MAY 2026

1. Tomatoes, peppers & eggplants are in the ground or going in now — last frost is behind most of Zone 7 by early April.
2. Direct sow beans, corn, cucumber, squash, zucchini & okra throughout April — Zone 7 is warm enough for all of them.
3. Harvest cool-season crops before they bolt — peas, lettuce, spinach, broccoli & cauliflower finish by late May. Pick at peak.

QUICK-START CROPS

Okra — Clemson Spineless (H) or Hill Country Red (OP)
Direct sow April, harvest June–October. Zone 7 is the sweet spot for okra.

Sweet potato — Beauregard (OP)
Plant slips late April (soil 65°F+). Harvest October. Stores for months.

Amish Paste tomato (H)
85 days, large paste type, exceptional for sauce, heat-tolerant for Zone 7 summers.

STORAGE & PRESERVATION

- Main preservation window July–October:
sweet potatoes, tomatoes, peppers, okra & beans.
- Okra freezes better than it cans — blanch 3 min, freeze on sheet pan, bag. Maintains texture.
Raleigh NC · Oklahoma City OK · Seattle WA inland
 - Sweet potato curing (10 days at 85–90°F, then 55–60°F storage) extends shelf life to 6–12 months.

ZONE
7

Piedmont South, Oklahoma,
North Texas, Maritime
Northwest

HEIRLOOM VARIETY SPOTLIGHT

Amish Paste tomato (H)
85 days, large meaty paste type, adapted to Southeastern heat. Superior sauce tomato for Zone 7.

Clemson Spineless okra (H)
1939 All-America Selections winner, still the standard. Productive, spineless, 56 days.

Beauregard sweet potato (OP)
90 days, copper skin, orange flesh. Most reliable sweet potato for Zone 7 home gardeners.